X-TREME PHOTO

PHOTO PREP

Staff User Guide

Version 2.3.9 · October 2026

Prep, Edit and Export for green-screen show photos

X-treme Photo Services
For staff use

Software by Ozark Mountain AI LLC
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CONTENTS

01	About this guide	1
02	Quick start: a normal night	1
03	The screen at a glance	2
04	Step 1: Prep	2
05	Step 2: Edit — the photo list	3
06	Edit tools, one by one	5
07	AI Optimize + Verify	7
08	Templates	8
09	Step 3: Export	9
10	Installing, updating and uninstalling	10
11	Troubleshooting and FAQ	12
12	Keyboard shortcuts and glossary	12

New to Photo Prep? Read Quick start first, then keep this guide by the workstation. Problems go to the owner, with the photo and the error log (see Troubleshooting).

SECTION 01

About this guide

Photo Prep turns a night's green-screen photos into finished prints in three steps: **Prep**, **Edit**, **Export**. It replaces FXhome PhotoKey 6 Pro at X-treme Photo Services and works the same way where it can: tools on the left, the photo in the middle, a toolbox on the right.

This guide is the reference for staff. Read Quick start once, then come back to the section for whatever you are doing.

Two rules hold everywhere in the app:

- **Nothing is tied to a venue or a person.** There are no logins, no PINs and no venue lists. The app opens blank, and staff load the template for the show they are shooting.
- **Originals are never changed.** Prep writes copies into a separate folder. Edit and Export work from those copies. The photos off the camera card stay exactly as shot.

Photo Prep is developed by Ozark Mountain AI LLC and licensed to X-treme Photo Services. The version number is in the bottom-right corner of the window.

This guide is built into the app. Click **User Guide** at the bottom of the Photo Prep window, or press **F1**, to open it. It always matches the version installed.

SECTION 02

Quick start: a normal night

Most nights take five steps: open the show's template, Prep the card, check the AI's work, nudge what needs it, Export.

1. **Open the template.** Double-click the show's `.pptemplate` file, or in Edit click **Open...** next to the Template box. The backgrounds, overlay, caption and print size load with it.
2. **Prep the card.** Go to **1 Prep**, click **Browse...** next to *Pick the night's photos* and choose the card's folder. Tick **AI Optimize every photo when prep finishes**, then click **Start**.
3. **Check the AI's work.** When Prep finishes, click **Next: Edit**. Step through the photos with **Page Down** / **Page Up** or the ▲ ▼ buttons under the preview. Photos the AI couldn't fix carry a **⚠ check** tag.
4. **Nudge what needs it.** Fix the tagged photos first. If you want to move or resize people photo by photo, press **Ctrl+A** in the photo list, right-click and set them to **Unique** first. On Global photos, a move happens on every photo.
5. **Export.** Go to **3 Export**, check the printer's hot folder, and click **Batch Export**. Tagged photos are held back until someone edits them.

> **Tip.** no green screen at this account? Skip Prep. In Edit, click **Import** under the photo list instead. See

> *Importing without Prep* in the Edit section.

SECTION 03

The screen at a glance

The three steps are tabs at the top right; Edit, where most of the work happens, is laid out like PhotoKey.

AREA	WHERE	WHAT IT'S FOR
Step tabs	Top right: **1 Prep**, **2 Edit**, **3 Export**	Move between the three steps. You can go back and forth at any time.
Template bar	Edit, across the top	Template name box with **Open...**, **Save**, **New**; the view dropdown (**Full Color**, **Alpha**, **Foreground Original**); the sample dropdown (**Quarter**, **Half**, **Full Sample**); **Previous** / **Next** photo.
Tool list	Edit, left side	Canvas, Import, AI, Key, Masks, Filters, Position, Layers, Effects, Overlay, Text, Batch Export. Click one to show its settings in the Toolbox.
Preview	Edit, centre	The finished print as it will export. Yellow boxes on it can be dragged.
Under the preview	Edit, below the photo	The **star** (Global or Unique for this photo), **Foreground** / **Background** tick boxes to hide either while you work, and ▲ ▼ to step through photos.
Toolbox	Edit, right side	The settings for the tool you picked, plus **Apply to all** and **Reset All** at the bottom.
Status line	Bottom of the Toolbox	Green = done, orange = needs a look. Read it after every action.
Footer	Very bottom	*Developed by Ozark Mountain AI LLC* (click for the About box) and the version number.

View modes. *Full Color* is the print. *Alpha* shows the cut-out in black and white (white = kept, black = keyed out): use it to spot holes or leftover green. *Foreground Original* shows the photo as shot.

Sample sizes. The preview opens on *Half Sample*: as sharp as the print at the size it's shown, and quick to update. *Quarter Sample* is faster but looks soft, so don't judge focus on it. *Full Sample* renders the whole print size for zooming in on fine detail; it's slower to update. Export always renders at full size.

SECTION 04

Step 1: Prep

Prep makes clean copies of the night's photos, ready to key: it fixes red eye and paints everything outside the green screen (walls, floor, light stands) the same green, so Edit only has one green to remove.

To run it:

1. Click **Browse…** next to *Pick the night's photos* and choose the folder from the card.
2. Leave the output folder as it is. Prepped copies go into a **Prepped** folder inside the input folder.
3. Tick the options you want (below) and click **Start**. **Stop** halts it; nothing already finished is lost.
4. When it's done, **Start** becomes **Next: Edit**, and the prepped photos open in Edit automatically.

OPTION	DEFAULT	WHAT IT DOES
Fix red eye	On	Finds faces and removes red from pupils. Only the pupils change, never skin.
Fill off-screen areas with green	On	Paints walls, floor and stands outside the curtain backdrop green. People, and anything they're holding, are left alone.
AI Optimize every photo when prep finishes	Off	Runs AI Optimize + Verify on every photo right after Prep, so the card comes out print-ready. Recommended.
Skip photos already in output	Off	Re-running Prep on the same folder only does new photos. Photos prepped by an older version of the person rules are redone automatically.
Watch input folder for new photos	Off	Keeps running and preps new photos as they land in the folder, e.g. straight off a tethered camera. Pairs with Edit's **Hot Folder**.
Save before/after previews	Off	Writes side-by-side previews into a `_previews` folder, for checking Prep's work.
Green sensitivity	25	Lower = more shades count as green. Leave it at 25 unless the log flags problems.

The log. Prep writes `_photo_prep_log.csv` into the Prepped folder. Rows marked **CHECK** are worth a human look: *no green backdrop, fill skipped* (the photo had no green screen and was left alone), *large fill* (an unusually big area was painted), or *could not process* (the file wouldn't open).

Originals are never changed. Prep only ever writes into the Prepped folder.

SECTION 05

Step 2: Edit — the photo list

The photo list lives under **Import › Foreground**: one row per photo, with a star and a tag. Everything you do in Edit happens on the photo selected there.

Moving through photos. Click a row, use ▲ ▼ under the preview, **Page Up** / **Page Down**, or **Previous** / **Next** in the top bar. Type in **Search** to filter by file name; **Name ↑ / Name ↓** flips the sort.

Tags on each row:

TAG	MEANING
⚠ check	The AI couldn't fix something. Held out of Export until someone edits the photo.

TAG	MEANING
edited	Someone changed this photo by hand.
AI ✓	AI Optimize ran and verified it clean.
as shot	Imported with no green screen; used as shot (see below).

Hot Folder. Tick **Use Hot Folder** and new photos from Prep (with *Watch input folder* on) appear in the list as they're prepped.

Remove takes the selected photo out of this batch. The original and its prepped copy stay on disk; prepping it again brings it back.

Importing without Prep

Import (under the photo list) brings photos straight into Edit, skipping Prep. Use it for accounts that don't shoot on green screen, or to add a few photos to the open batch.

- **No green screen:** the photo is used *as shot*. It fills the print and isn't keyed, and the row is tagged **as shot**. Red eye, filters, layers, overlay, text and AI Optimize all still work. The Key tool notes that its settings don't apply.
- **Green screen:** keyed as usual, without Prep's green fill.
- Red eye on imported photos is fixed live, so unticking *Red Eye* in the Key tool brings the original eyes back.
- If you later run the same photos through Prep, they're treated as normal prepped photos from then on.

Global and Unique (the star)

Every photo starts **Global** (hollow star). A change on a Global photo — key, filters, position, layers, effects, overlay size and spot, text — happens on **every** Global photo. **Unique** (gold star) photos keep their own copy of everything. Masks and manual red-eye fixes always belong to one photo.

- **One photo:** click its star in the list, or the star under the preview.
- **Several:** select them (**Ctrl+A** for all, or Ctrl/Shift-click), right-click, choose **Set … to Unique** (or **Global**).
- **The usual night:** set the look while everything is Global, run AI Optimize All, then **Ctrl+A › Unique** before nudging people photo by photo.
- Setting a photo back to Global drops its own settings; it follows the shared ones again.

Apply to all makes this photo's look the shared setting and puts every photo on Global; each keeps its own position. **Reset All** puts this photo back on the shared settings. The small ↺ arrow on a section resets just that section to how the template had it.

SECTION 06

Edit tools, one by one

Each tool on the left opens its settings in the Toolbox. Most have a tick box to switch the section on or off and a ↺ arrow to put it back to the template's setting. Yellow boxes on the preview can be dragged: inside to move, a corner to resize, the circle to rotate.

Canvas

- **Print Size:** 6 × 8 inch (default) or 8 × 10 inch, landscape, 300 dpi. Every photo exports at this size. Saved in the template.
- **Canvas Color:** tick **Use Color** to put a plain colour behind the people instead of a background image.
- **People Placement:** how Auto-fit and the AI place the group, in X-treme house style. The bottom of the print cuts people at the **Cut-off** (share of standing height), then the group is made as big as fits under the **Headroom** (space above the tallest head) and no wider than **Max width**, centred. Feet never show.

GROUP	HEADROOM	MAX WIDTH	CUT-OFF
Couples and trios	13%	85%	56% (mid-thigh)
Big groups (5+)	10%	96%	84% (mid-shin)

A group of 4 is cut halfway between the two. These numbers were fitted to X-treme's own finished prints; change them only if the house style changes. They're saved in the template.

If someone is cut off at the side or top of the original shot, the photo is scaled so the cut sits on the print's edge instead of floating inside it.

Import

- **Foreground:** the photo list (see *Step 2: Edit*).
- **Background: Import** adds background images to the library; click one to put it behind every photo. **Remove** takes it out. **Zoom & Crop** uses just part of the picture: **Zoom** up to 500%, then **Left / Right** and **Up / Down** (±100 puts that edge of the picture on the print's edge), or drag its yellow box.

Key

The Key removes the green screen. The defaults suit X-treme's curtains; most nights you won't touch it.

- **Red Eye:** on by default (fixed in Prep, or live on imported photos). Untick to keep this photo's eyes as shot. **Missed one?** Click **Select Eyes**, drag an oval round each red eye (as many as you like; right-click takes the last one back), then click **Remove Red Eye**. Only the red of the pupil changes, never the skin. **Undo Manual Fixes** removes them. Manual fixes belong to this photo only. **Esc** leaves selecting.

- **Auto Color Difference: Color** (Green or Blue screen), **Removal** (how hard green is removed), **Detail** (more keeps finer hair), **Softness** (how soft the edge is).
- **Matte: Clip Backg.** / **Clip Foreg.** tidy almost-clear and almost-solid edges; **Erode/Expand** shrinks or grows the cut-out edge.
- **Alpha Blur:** softens the cut-out edge.
- **Spill Suppression:** removes green light bounced onto people. **Spill Simulation** replaces it with the new background's light; **Desaturate** greys it out. Green clothing (a green shirt, a purse, lettering) keeps its colour.

The AI person-finder guides the key: deep inside a person is always kept and far away from everyone is always removed, so green clothes stay and wrinkles in the curtain go.

Masks

For what the key gets wrong, like a stool left in the shot or a hand that went missing.

1. Click **Add Mask**, then click points around the area. Each point joins the last, and points can go outside the photo.
2. Close the loop by clicking the first (yellow) point, or press **Enter** / click **Done**. Nothing is cut until the loop is closed.
3. Drag points to adjust.

Type: Remove Alpha (default) cuts the area out; **Retain Alpha** forces it to stay. **Feather** softens the mask edge; **Invert** flips it. Masks always belong to one photo. **Esc** cancels drawing.

Filters

Foreground filters act on the people; **Background** filters act on the background image.

- **Auto Brightness** and **Auto White Balance** are the AI's, measured on the people's faces.
- PhotoKey's full list: Transparency, White Balance (eyedropper), Auto Levels, Auto Contrast, Auto Color, Brightness, Contrast, Saturation, Levels, Color Temperature, Color Balance, Hue Colorize, Hue Shift, Sharpen, Blur, Bilateral Blur, Defocus, Diffuse, Vibrance, Leave Color, Half Tone, Half Tone Color, Silhouette, and Shadow Cast (people only).
- Tick a filter to switch it on. The arrows change the order they're applied in.

Position

- **Foreground (the people): Auto-fit** sizes and centres them on the floor line using People Placement. **Position** (Horizontal / Vertical), **Scale**, **Rotation** (Angle) and **Flip Horizontal**. Or use the yellow box on the photo.
- **Background:** the same **Zoom & Crop** as in Import.

On a Global photo, moving people moves them on every Global photo. Set photos to Unique first if you want to nudge them one at a time.

Layers

For a prop, sign or logo between the background and the people, or in front of them.

- **Add Layer** and pick a PNG with transparency. A JPG works but shows as a box.
- **Size**, **Angle**, **Horizontal** / **Vertical**, or drag its yellow box. Tick **In front of the people** to put it on top. **Change image...** swaps the picture; **Remove Layer** deletes it.

Effects

- **Shadow Cast:** a soft shadow on the floor under the group. **Strength** sets how dark.
- **Light Wrap:** bleeds the background's light onto the edges of the people so they sit in the scene. **Amount** sets how much.

Overlay

The show's logo or frame on top of the print.

- **Load...** a PNG that's clear where the photo shows through. **Change...** swaps it; **Remove** takes it off.
- It starts in the bottom right. **Corner** switches between Bottom right and Bottom left. **Size**, **From side** and **From bottom** fine-tune it, or drag its yellow box (inside to move, a corner to resize).
- AI Optimize keeps it off faces and upper bodies (legs may run under a corner logo) and moves it to the other corner only if it has to.
- The overlay is saved inside the template.

Text

Add Text puts a caption on the print. `{date}` fills in the show date (from the photo's camera date). **Remove Text** takes it off.

SECTION 07

AI Optimize + Verify

One click makes a photo ready to print: the AI fixes brightness, places the people, puts them on the background, keeps the overlay clear, then checks its own work and retries up to 3 times. What it decides becomes that photo's settings, so the preview shows exactly what will export.

To run it: open the **AI** tool. **Optimize Photo** does the photo on screen; **Optimize All Photos** does the whole batch. Or tick *AI Optimize every photo when prep finishes* on the Prep page. When it's done, **Go to Export** stays pinned at the bottom of the AI panel.

Each step can be ticked off:

STEP	WHAT IT DOES
Fix brightness	Brightens dark shots and darkens bright ones, measured on the people's faces. Also sets white balance.
Center the people	Sizes and centres the group the X-treme way (Canvas › People Placement). On an *as shot* photo, the photo is kept as shot instead.
Put the background behind them	Uses the background picked in Import.
Keep the overlay clear	Keeps it off faces and upper bodies; moves it to the other corner if it has to.
Verify, and redo until clean	Scans each finished photo, fixes what it finds (up to 3 tries) and flags anything still wrong for a person.

When a photo is flagged

A flagged photo gets the ⚠ **check** tag and its reason in the status line. It's held out of Export until someone edits it.

THE AI SAYS	WHAT TO DO
no people found in the photo	Check it's the right photo. If people are there, mask them in (Masks › Retain Alpha) or place them by hand.
no background loaded	Import › Background, pick one.
someone cut off at the ... edge of the original shot doesn't reach the print's edge	The camera cut someone off. Press **Auto-fit**, or drag the people so the cut sits on the print's edge.
people run off the ... edge of the print	Press **Auto-fit**, or make them smaller (Position › Scale).
the overlay covers someone	Move the overlay (drag its box or switch the Corner), or make it smaller.
a face is too dark / too bright	Filters › Brightness, or Levels.
green fringe left on the edges	Key › Spill Suppression at 100, or Matte › Erode/Expand a little negative.

After fixing by hand, the tag changes to **edited** and the photo goes into Export.

Re-running the AI on a photo replaces its position and brightness with the AI's choices; masks, layers and manual red-eye fixes are kept.

SECTION 08

Templates

A template is one show's whole setup in a single `.pptemplate` file. Templates replace venues: set a show up once, save it, and any PC can open it.

What a template holds: print size, People Placement numbers, backgrounds (the images are packed inside), the overlay (packed inside), caption, layers, effects, and the shared key and filter settings. It doesn't hold photos.

Build one:

1. Click **New** to start blank.
2. Set Canvas, load backgrounds (Import › Background), load the overlay, add a caption and any layers or effects. You can do all of this before any photos are open; the preview shows the template on its own.
3. Key, people filters, people position and masks need a photo, since they work on the people. Open a few test photos to tune them.
4. Type the show's name in the **Template** box and click **Save**. Templates save to *Documents › Photo Prep Templates* by default.

Open one:

- **Double-click** the `.pptemplate` file in File Explorer. Template files show the Photo Prep template icon. If Photo Prep is already open, the template loads into the open window.
- Or click **Open...** in Edit.
- Opening a template resets photo edits to the template's look, so it asks first if any photos have edits.

Share between PCs: the template is one file with every image inside it, so it works the same from Dropbox, a shared drive or a USB stick. Edit it on one PC, save, and copy the file to the others.

New clears everything back to blank. The app always opens blank; nothing is tied to a location or a person.

SECTION 09

Step 3: Export

Export renders every finished photo at full print size. By default the prints go into a **Ready to Print** folder, made next to the **Prepped** folder inside the night's photo folder:

```
Card folder (the night's photos, never changed)
├── Prepped          ← Prep's copies, what Edit works on
└── Ready to Print   ← finished prints from Export
```

1. Check the top lines: the **Template** in use, how many photos will export, and any held back.
2. Under **Save to**, leave **Save to a "Ready to Print" folder next to Prepped** ticked. To send prints somewhere else, like the printer's hot folder, untick it and pick the folder with **Browse...**. Photo Prep remembers your choice.
3. Click **Batch Export**. **Stop** halts it; photos already written stay.

SETTING	DEFAULT	WHAT IT DOES
Print size	From Canvas	Shown for checking; change it in Edit › Canvas.
Format	JPG	JPG, TIFF or PNG.
Quality	100	JPG quality. Leave at 100 for prints.
Prefix / Suffix	Blank	Added before and after the file name. The *Example* line shows the result.
Embed color profile (sRGB)	On	Keeps colours consistent on the printer.
Keep the camera's photo info (EXIF)	On	Keeps the camera date and settings in the file.
Use Batched Backgrounds	Off	Exports every photo on **each** background in the library; the background's name is added to the file name.
Also save screen-size copies for a sales display	Off	Writes smaller copies for showing on a screen.
Save to a "Ready to Print" folder next to Prepped	On	Prints go in that night's photo folder. Untick to choose another folder.
Open the print folder when done	On	Opens the folder in File Explorer at the end.

Held-back photos. Photos tagged ⚠ **check** don't export. The orange line under the count says how many. Fix or edit them in Edit, then click Batch Export again.

SECTION 10

Installing, updating and uninstalling

Photo Prep needs Windows 10 or 11, 64-bit. It installs for the signed-in Windows user, so no administrator password is needed.

JOB	HOW
New PC	Run **Photo Prep [version] Setup.exe** once (about a minute). It adds a *Photo Prep* icon to the desktop and Start menu; use that icon from then on.
Update	Automatic from version 2.3.9 on (below). By hand if ever needed: close Photo Prep, then run **Photo Prep [version] update.exe** once. It keeps Python and the AI models already on the PC and only swaps in the new app (a few seconds).
Uninstall	Settings › Apps › Installed apps › Photo Prep › Uninstall. It removes the app and shortcuts, asks before deleting saved templates, and never touches photos.

Automatic updates

Photo Prep updates itself. Staff don't need to do anything.

1. When Photo Prep opens, and every 4 hours after, it checks X-treme's update page for a newer version.
2. A newer version downloads in the background and is checked against its fingerprint, so a damaged download is thrown away.
3. The footer shows **Update [version] ready - installs when you close Photo Prep**. Nothing installs during Prep, AI or Export.
4. Close Photo Prep as normal at the end of the night. The update installs in a few seconds, and the next time anyone opens it, the footer says **Updated to [version]**. If the PC was switched off instead, it installs the next time someone opens Photo Prep.
5. If a new version fails to open three times in a row, the previous version is put back automatically and that update is skipped.

FOOTER SAYS	MEANING
Update [version] ready - installs when you close Photo Prep	Nothing to do. Close Photo Prep when you're finished.
Updated to [version]	The update installed.
Update [version] was blocked by Windows Security	Windows quarantined the download. Follow *Windows security warnings* below, then click the footer message to check again.
Photo Prep [version] is out and needs the full installer	That release changes the AI models or Python. Tell the owner; it needs the full Setup.exe.

No internet? Photo Prep works normally and checks again later.

After an update to the person rules, Prep redoes previously prepped batches the next time it runs on them, even with *Skip photos already in output* ticked. That's deliberate.

Windows security warnings

Photo Prep isn't digitally signed yet, so Windows may warn about it. These warnings are false alarms.

- **"Windows protected your PC"** (blue box): click **More info**, then **Run anyway**.
- **Windows Security quarantines it** (*Trojan:Win32/Wacatac...!ml*): the `!ml` means Defender's machine-learning guess, not a known virus. Open **Windows Security › Virus & threat protection › Protection history**, click the entry, then **Actions › Restore** (or **Allow on device**).
- To stop it recurring on a PC: **Virus & threat protection › Manage settings › Exclusions › Add an exclusion › Folder**, and add the folder you keep the installers in plus `%LOCALAPPDATA%\Photo Prep`.

> Only do this for files that came from the owner. If a warning names a specific threat without `!ml`, don't restore it; tell the owner.

SECTION 11

Troubleshooting and FAQ

PROBLEM	FIX
Green showing between arms or legs	Switch the view to **Alpha** to see it. Mask it out (Masks › Remove Alpha) and tell the owner which photo; it helps tune the AI.
Part of someone is missing (a dark shirt, a hand)	Mask it back in with **Retain Alpha**, and report the photo.
Green tint on hair or edges	Key › Spill Suppression at 100; or Matte › Erode/Expand slightly negative.
Moving one photo moved them all	That photo was Global. Undo by pressing **Auto-fit**, then set photos to **Unique** before nudging.
A photo won't export	It's tagged ⚠ **check**. Read its reason, fix it, and export again.
Preview looks soft	You're probably on Quarter Sample. Switch back to **Half Sample** (the default); Full Sample for fine detail. The export is always full size.
Photo with no green screen	Import it from Edit (it comes in *as shot*) instead of running Prep.
Red eye missed	Key › Red Eye › **Select Eyes**, drag ovals, **Remove Red Eye**. Red eye is found automatically only when the whole face is in the shot.
"Photo Prep is already open"	It's running already; check the taskbar.
Something went wrong and the app restarted	Your template comes back automatically; reopen the batch from Prep's output folder if needed.
Windows Security deleted it	See *Windows security warnings* above.

Does the preview show the AI's changes, or are they only applied on export? The preview shows them. Everything the AI decides is saved as that photo's settings, and Export renders the same settings at full size.

Does Photo Prep change my original photos? Never. Prep writes copies, and Edit and Export work from those.

Where's the error log? `%LOCALAPPDATA%\Photo Prep\photo_prep_errors.log`. Paste that path into File Explorer's address bar. Send it to the owner with any problem report, along with the photo.

SECTION 12

Keyboard shortcuts and glossary

KEYS	DOES
F1	Open this user guide

KEYS	DOES
Page Down / Page Up	Next / previous photo
Ctrl+A (in the photo list)	Select every photo
Ctrl-click / Shift-click	Select several photos
Right-click (photo list)	Set the selected photos to Unique or Global
Enter	Close the mask you're drawing
Esc	Stop drawing a mask, stop selecting eyes, or cancel the eyedropper
Right-click (while selecting eyes)	Take back the last oval

TERM	MEANING
Prep	Step 1: makes clean copies with red eye fixed and off-screen areas painted green.
Prepped folder	Where Prep's copies go, inside the card's folder.
Key / keying	Removing the green screen so the background can go behind people.
Alpha	The cut-out: white is kept, black is removed.
Spill	Green light from the screen bounced onto people's edges and hair.
As shot	A photo imported with no green screen; used whole, not keyed.
Global / Unique	Shared settings across photos (hollow star) / this photo's own settings (gold star).
Template	One show's setup saved as a `.pptemplate` file.
Overlay	The show's logo or frame PNG on top of every print.
Layer	An extra PNG (a prop or sign) placed behind or in front of the people.
Ready to Print	The folder Export saves prints into by default, next to Prepped.
Hot folder	The folder a printer watches; Export can write there instead. Edit's *Use Hot Folder* is a different thing: it shows photos as Prep finishes them.
⚠ check	A photo the AI couldn't fix; held out of Export until edited.